

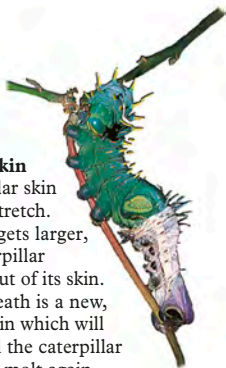
CATERPILLARS



Caterpillars are like tiny eating machines. They spend most of their time chomping on leaves. Caterpillars are actually the young of butterflies and moths. They hatch from the eggs the adult female has laid on plants. With constant eating they get bigger and bigger, until they are ready to change into adult butterflies and moths.

A new skin

Caterpillar skin cannot stretch. So as it gets larger, the caterpillar breaks out of its skin. Underneath is a new, larger skin which will last until the caterpillar needs to molt again.



Hatching out

The butterfly's eggs are laid on the underside of a leaf.



The caterpillar uses its jaws to bite its way out of the egg.



The caterpillar pulls itself free of the eggshell and takes its first walk.



The caterpillar's first meal is the eggshell itself, which is full of good food.

Caterpillars produce silk from special glands and force it out through a spinneret under the head.

Caterpillars have twelve tiny, simple eyes, called ocelli, on their head.

The caterpillar's head is armed with a pair of stout jaws called mandibles.

Caterpillars test food and guide it to their mouth with mouthparts called maxillary palps.

The front three pairs of legs are called thoracic legs, and are used for walking and claspings.

The body is divided into 13 segments.

